

ARCHITECTURE

The man who kept nature in the city

Boston's 'Emerald Necklace' of parks was only one of Olmsted's American masterpieces

PHOTOS COURTESY THE NATIONAL PARK SERVICE,
FREDERICK LAW OLMSTED NATIONAL HISTORIC SITE



Frederick Law Olmsted

By Robert Campbell

Frederick Law Olmsted, the man who designed Boston's "Emerald Necklace," was one of those unbelievable Victorians who accomplished far more, without the help of word processors or 747s, than we pygmies of today can ever seem to hope for.

He reminds you of his contemporary Anthony Trollope, who dashed off his 50-odd novels, many of them classics, with a quill pen in the early mornings without ever having to work past breakfast. I've always thought that the vast output of the great Victorians had something to do with the fact that they were never interrupted by time-saving devices like ringing telephones.

Olmsted was the founder of American landscape architecture. He designed, with his partners, 89 parks in 30 states. His works include Central Park in New York, Prospect Park in Brooklyn, the grounds of the US Capital in Washington, the site plan for Stanford University, Mount Royal park in Montreal, the plan of the World's Columbian Exposition in Chicago, an elaborate system of linked parks and park-

Olmsted's achievement in Boston was staggering. The city would today be nearly unrecognizable without the works of this Victorian genius.

ways in Buffalo and Biltmore, the 125,000-acre estate of George Vanderbilt in Asheville, N.C.

Probably nothing Olmsted did, however, compares with his contribution to Boston, where he eventually settled. The city would today be nearly unrecognizable without the works of this genius. Indeed, it's arguable that Olmsted deserves first place among the shapers of the city, ahead of architects like his friend H.H. Richardson or I.M. Pei or Charles Bulfinch, and of planners like Josiah Quincy and Edward Logue.

Thus it's appropriate that Boston will be host to the convention of the National Association for Olmsted Parks. The convention, running from April 23-26, is an opportunity for Boston to reacquaint itself with a great but often neglected heritage. Information on events can be obtained from program coordinator Betsy Gross (Ph. 731-1448).

The Olmsted Association, only two years old, is already a nationwide group with regional affiliates in eight major cities. It works to preserve and restore Olmsted's fame and the Olmsted parks.

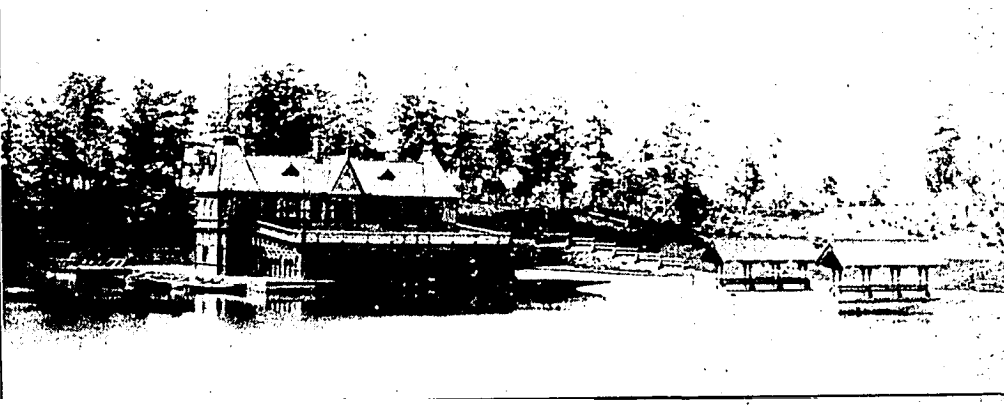
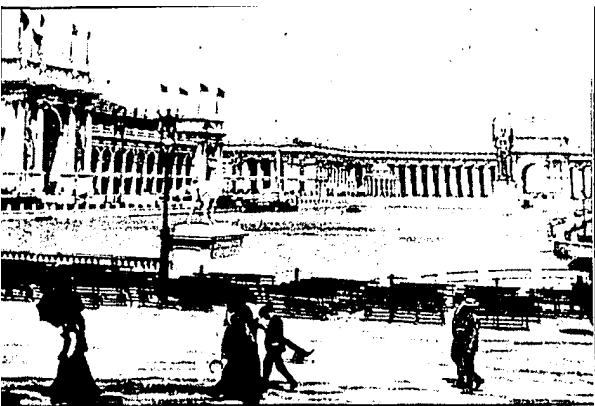
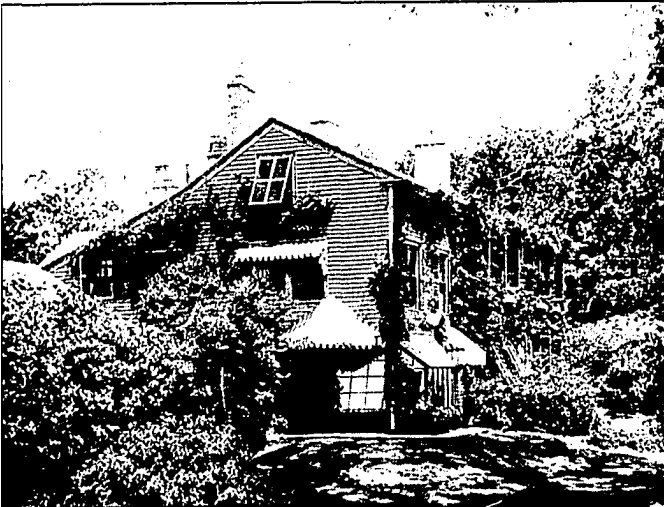
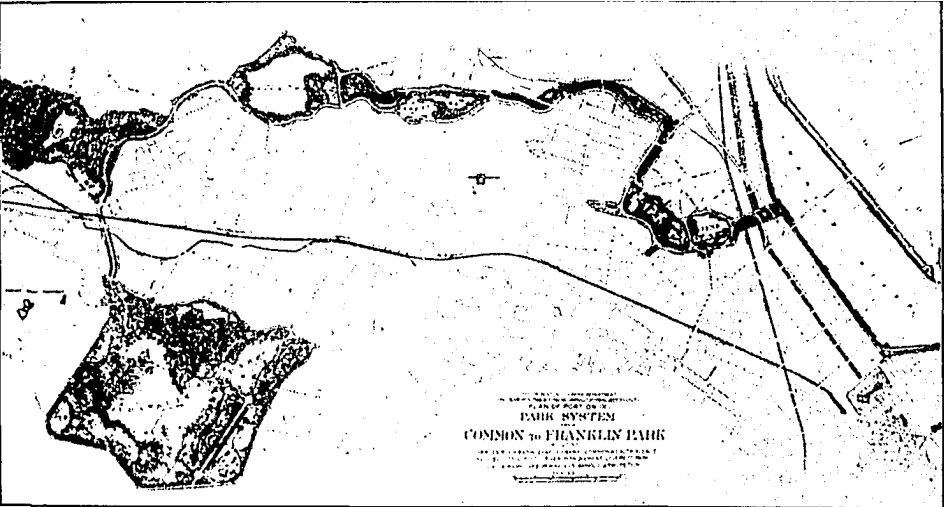
Among the Association's projects has been the saving of Fairsted, Olmsted's home and office in Brookline. The archives at Fairsted contain 115,000 of the Olmsted firm's drawings. This successful effort will culminate at the convention when Fairsted will be dedicated as a National Historic Site.

Olmsted came late to his spectacular career, a fact which is one of the appealing things about him. His misspent youth was supported by periodic handouts from a loyal father. Unable to settle down, Olmsted tried one career after another. He spend a year sailing to China, failed at farming, succeeded at journalism. His articles for the New York Times about the American South in the years before the Civil War are minor classics. He helped found and edit the magazine The Nation, headed the US Sanitary Commission, during the Civil War, and ran a mining settlement in California.

The job of creating Central Park fell to Olmsted largely by chance. With this work, done in collaboration with Calvert Vaux, he finally found his career and went on to inaugurate a new profession as well.

In Olmsted's time, American cities were growing very quickly because of the Industrial revolution. As they became larger and more crowded, they lost any sense of contact with nature. Yet this was also the time when the Romantic cum-nature-loving philosophy of Wordsworth and Emerson was dominant. So it was inevitable that some attempt would be made to bring nature back to the world of the city dweller. After Olmsted showed how to do it with his Central Park, every city wanted its own park, and Olmsted spent the rest of his life greening America. By the time he died, he had trained many helpers in this work. In 1900, Harvard established the first professional degree in landscape architecture and chose Olmsted's son, Frederick Law Jr., to head it.

As it was everywhere, Olmsted's achievement in Boston was staggering. He created Franklin Park and then performed



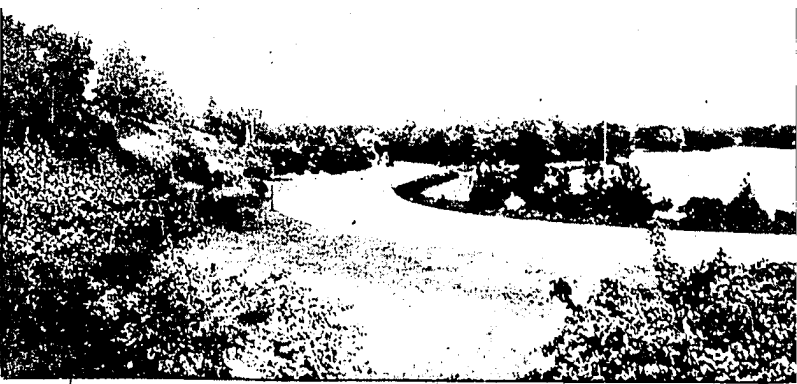
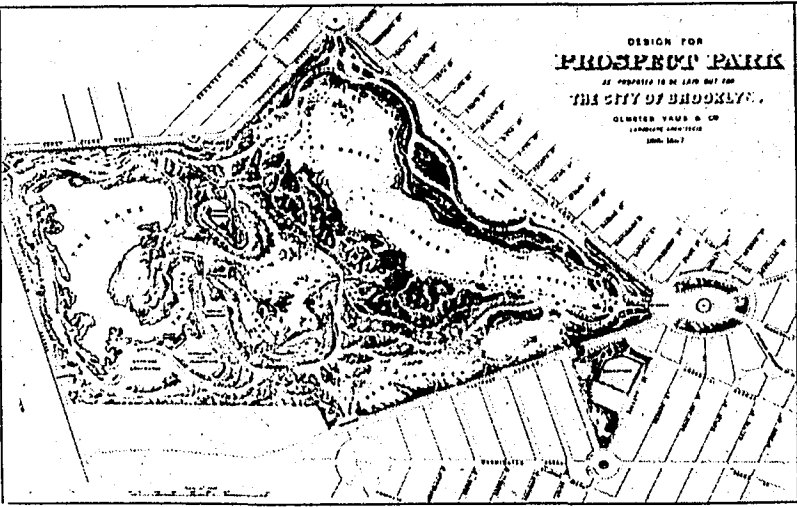
the great feat of linking this park in suburban Roxbury/Brookline with Boston Common, seven miles away.

To do this, Olmsted drained the Muddy River and transformed it into the Back Bay Fens. He connected the Fens with Commonwealth Avenue, then in progress, which he realigned and extended to Kenmore Square. He planted the Commonwealth Avenue Mall and thus completed what came to be called the Emerald Necklace, an unbroken chain of green jewels, comprising the Boston Common, the Public Garden, Commonwealth Avenue Mall, the Fens, Leverett Pond, Jamaica Pond, the Arnold Arboretum and Franklin Park.

Olmsted passed his work on to his sons, and the firm lasted a total of 123 years. Its archives today are a priceless repository of American landscape history.

Among the events at the Olmsted convention is an exhibition, "Olmsted in America," now on view at the Harvard Graduate School of Design. Also at Harvard will be a lecture by the noted landscape architect Lawrence Halprin, who conceived San Francisco's Ghirardelli Square. There will be presentations and seminars on various aspects of Olmsted, and guided tours of the Olmsted parks. Scheduled to speak are Sen. Edward Kennedy, Boston Mayor Kevin White, Boston Parks Comr. John Vitagliano, and New York Times architecture critic Paul Goldberg.

Olmsted thought of his parks as a kind of civilized nature. Though he admired wilderness and helped establish Yosemite National Park, he avoided violent drama in his own work, preferring to create quiet, picturesque parks that suggest an idealized country setting. He spoke more often of the social benefits of his parks than of



Counterclockwise from top: The Riverway at Longwood Bridge shortly after its completion in 1920; the plan for Olmsted's "Emerald Necklace" in Boston; part of the 1893 World's Columbian Exposition in Chicago, which Olmsted planned; part of a series of linked Olmsted parks in Buffalo, N.Y.; Fairsted, Olmsted's home in Brookline. Left: the plan for Prospect Park in Brooklyn, N.Y. and an interior view of the park.

their esthetics. Though his parks appear natural, they are really artificial creations. Central Park was a treeless dumpsite before Olmsted.

History hasn't always dealt kindly with Olmsted. Freeways now slice the Emerald Necklace. And there are new threats. The Reagan Administration is proposing huge cuts in the federal programs that help support historic sites like the parks.

But attacks on Olmsted are nothing new and so far, at least, his heritage has survived them. Olmsted himself spent so much time and became so excited by fighting misguided attempts to change his parks that some scholars think the strain helped drive him, as an old man, into madness.

Even Olmsted's madness had a landscaping aspect. He was confined to McLean Hospital in Belmont, the grounds of which (like almost everything else, it seems) he had designed himself some 20 years before. He made his bed, and then he lay down on it.

The rest of us, too, are lying on the beds Olmsted made. The Olmsted convention is a welcome reminder of that fact; and of the career of one of the greatest Americans.

Robert Campbell is the Globe's architecture critic.